

Making of a Stop sign

Check out this hilarious video on product design at its worst.
<http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/stop>

**The Kindle flaw**

Amazon's first generation ebook reader, Kindle is criticised for having over sensitive page turn buttons

Design Flops

Ludicrous compulsions force companies typically renowned for their design sensibilities to end up creating massive blunders. Let us delve into what happens when design goes bad.

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Albert Einstein once said “The intuitive mind is a sacred gift and the rational mind is a faithful servant. We have created a society that honours the servant and has forgotten the gift.” However, this maxim does not hold true when it comes to product designers who have to stretch the boundaries of creativity to come up with products that aspire to become the next big thing. Often in this process designers lose sight of things that are important such as rationality and common sense. We, the aesthetically challenged lot, get a glimpse of this in the movie *Elizabethtown* – a humorous take on a product designer who falls from grace when he ends up making a shoe that goes on to become not just a failure, but a fiasco of mythic proportions. Like the case of products in real life we don't know exactly what went wrong with the shoe except for the fact that it was inspired by a stingray and ended up looking really stupid when worn. Not many people would want a fish on their feet right?

There can be several things that go into making a bad design. Aesthetics – as in the case of the above narrative, is just one example. We tend to overlook these fauxpas and focus on the products that are design successes. The fact remains that good design is difficult to come by. The bulk of the products – especially in the consumer goods segment – are badly designed. They are inefficient, cumbersome, difficult to use, and will not have any of the elements that we've come to expect out of good design. Products by and large are wasteful, and worst of all, not nice to look at or touch.

So why exactly do product designs fail? It can't be that designers set out to make crappy designs. Somewhere along the way the goal probably gets obscured by mitigating factors and the end result is a sub-optimal product. The standard set of reasons like budgetary constraints,

time crunch and lack of talent can't be helped. There are however some ludicrous compulsions due to which companies known for their good design sensibilities end up creating blunders of epic proportions. Flops can happen to anyone. Flops can happen in any category of products. Heck, flops can happen to an entire category of products. Buckminster Fuller, the famous architect and futurist put it quite succinctly when he said “When I am working on a problem I never think about beauty. I only think about how to solve the problem. But when I have finished, if the solution is not beautiful, I know it is wrong.”

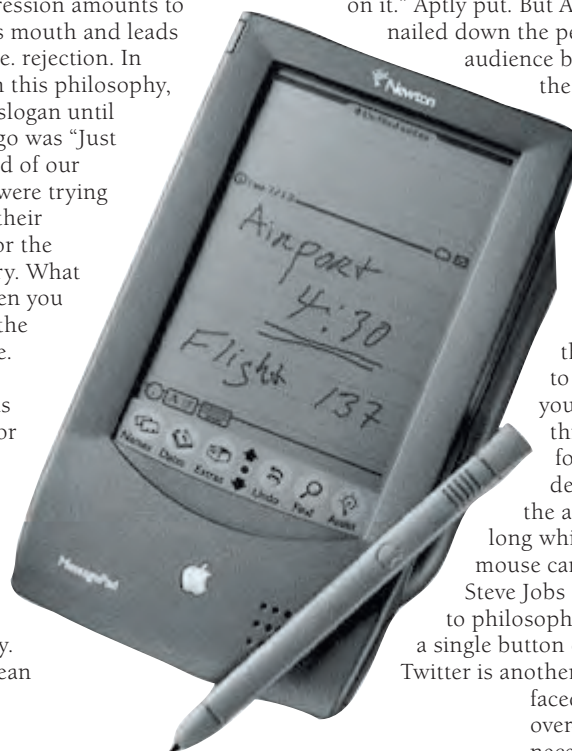
Too ahead of its time

Designs and products that go beyond the norms of what is acceptable for that point in time usually don't work. Consumers want to be fed changes one mouthful at a time. Progression amounts to stuffing ones mouth and leads to choking i.e. rejection. In keeping with this philosophy, Panasonic's slogan until some time ago was “Just slightly ahead of our time”. They were trying to proclaim their semblance for the contemporary. What happens when you don't? Take the case of Apple. Some of the best products recognised for their design have come from the gloriously creative drawing boards of this company. Does that mean

the giant is immune to design failures? Certainly not. In 1993 Apple launched a product that would go on to become the precursor to an entire category of products (PDAs or Palm Pilots as they're wrongly known) – the Apple Newton MessagePad. The device however was criticised for being too bulky and the handwriting recognition software on it too buggy. Perhaps they were hasty with incorporating handwriting recognition when underlying technological infrastructure was not quite in place. A blogger on networkworld.com said, “What these reviews don't tell you is that Apple did get the handwriting recognition down soon after its initial release, to the point where the handwriting recognition worked as fast a typing, at least for me. But since most Americans can't write, the Newton is an easy target for using ‘selective memory’ in the media blurbs on it.” Aptly put. But Apple should have nailed down the peculiarities of its audience before the releasing the product.

Too simple?

Forgive us, but Apple comes into the picture again. Case in point; Mac and its single click mouse. Agreed that things need to be simple, but do you need to dumb things down so much for the common denominator of the audience? For a long while up until the mouse came into being, Steve Jobs stubbornly stuck to philosophy of having a single button on a mouse. Twitter is another product that faced the problem of over-simplicity that necessitated a whole



The Apple Newton MessagePad was criticised for faulty handwriting recognition